THE FIRST KASHMIR WAR, 1947–48

Occupying an area of 222,870 square kilometres, predominantly Muslim Kashmir was ruled by a Hindu, Maharaja Hari Singh. On 12 August 1947, Hari Singh sent a proposal for a standstill agreement to both India and Pakistan, but only Pakistan agreed to the proposal. On 20 August, the Pakistan Army commenced Operation *Gulmarg* to annex Kashmir by force. By early September 1947, 20 *lashkars* (tribal militias), each 1,000 strong, were recruited and armed by the Pakistan Army. On 2 and 3 September, a band of 400 armed raiders infiltrated into Kashmir, followed by intrusions by the Pakistan Army and hit-and-run attacks all along the frontier. Compelled to disperse their assets into platoon-strength garrisons, the Kashmiri forces ceased to exist as a cohesive entity. Reaching Abbottabad on 18 October and crossing into Kashmir on 22 October, the invading forces sent ten *lashkars* to attack the Kashmir Valley through Muzaffarabad and another ten *lashkars* to join the local uprisings in Poonch, Bhimber and Rawalakot with a view to advancing to Jammu.

Notified of the invasion of Kashmir on 24 October, the Indian government received an urgent message from Maharaja Hari Singh, asking India to provide troops to defend Kashmir from the invaders. The Government of India, however, decided to send troops only after a formal accession of the state to India. Hari Singh signed the Instrument of Accession on 26 October and the first Indian troops landed in Kashmir the next day.

A company of 1 SIKH landed at Srinagar airfield by 0830hrs on 27 October and by 1000hrs Lieutenant Colonel Dewan Ranjit Rai’s tactical headquarters and two more companies had arrived. Receiving word that the raiders had reached the outskirts of Baramulla, Rai rushed his D Coy there to reinforce the state forces, thereby halting the advancing militia and saving Srinagar; but Rai fell during the battle. Severely outnumbered, D Coy made a fighting withdrawal towards Srinagar, establishing a blocking position on a commanding height 20km from the city and holding up the raiders’ advance for several days.